By the following year, it ‘completed the acquisition of [a] 74 % equity stake in Maithon Power Limited (MPL) from Damodar Valley Corporation’ in Jharkhand. This was done on Ratan’s specific direction as he was keen for the company to expand beyond Mumbai and Jamshedpur, says Sinha. Jharkhand, where the Tatas had set their first large enterprise, TISCO, had been carved out of Bihar in 2000, and Ratan considered it the group’s moral duty to participate in the development of the new state. The venture was a success—it gives Tata Power around Rs 300 crore of PAT per annum, Sinha adds.

In its quest for expansion, Tata Power explored any and every good opportunity. With Ratan at the helm, it was all about scale, modern technology and size, whether it was for the group or for projects that he was convinced were necessary for the accelerated growth of the nation. In 2004, Ratan was appointed the chairman of the Investment Commission of India by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. In February 2006, he submitted the report of the commission to the Prime Minister. The 100-page report contained a slew of recommendations with detailed analyses of the ‘Current Investment Levels’, ‘Required Levels of Investment’ and ‘Sectoral Analysis’. In the scheme of things, the power sector was identified as a ‘National Thrust Area’, imperative for the economic development of the country. The report recommended that ‘over 90,000 MW of new generation capacity’ was ‘required to meet the “power for all” target by 2012’.

The central government accepted the idea after a presentation made by Ratan to the Prime Minister. During the meeting, Finance Minister P. Chidambaram and Deputy Chairman, Planning Commission, Montek Singh Ahluwalia were also present, says Engineer who, as the MD of Tata Power, partook in the discussions. During the presentation, Ratan said that to make meaningful strides in the sector, it would be necessary to pursue large projects using supercritical boiler technology, though this had not yet been adopted in the country. He saw it as the only solution to address India’s power problem.

The government accepted this proposal and took up the ambitious project of Ultra Mega Power Projects (UMPPs). To implement the policy, the government floated a competitive tariff-based bidding process for the installation of the Mundra Ultra Mega Power Project, considered a ‘blueprint for the power sector in the country to achieve quality, reliable and sufficient power to achieve the GDP growth rate target’. Ratan decided that